developed elaborate ritual practices, with the use of symbols like the ‘vajra’ or thunderbolt, and the bell. The well-known Kalachakra ceremony performed by His Holiness the Dalai Lama is an elaborate ritual drawn from the Tantric tradition, with complex symbolism.

The worship of Buddhist deities and performance of ritual ceremonies trickled into China from Tibet, particularly during Mongol rule in China (1227–1368 CE ). But Tantrism never took hold in China, remaining at the margins of the Buddhist faith. With the interruption of the once-constant traffic of pilgrims and scholars between the two countries, Buddhism in China began to take on a more local character with its own elaborations of the original doctrines received from India. Several centres of Buddhist scholarship and worship were also established, such as Wutaishan, a well-known and sacred place of pilgrimage. Hereafter, contacts between India and China were maintained through the maritime route and involved the flourishing kingdoms and trade emporia along the Malabar coast, like Kochi (Cochin) and Kozhikode (Calicut), and Bharuch (Broach) further north in Gujarat.

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We will now go back in time to examine in more detail the Chinese view of India during the first millennium, which was shaped mainly by the spread of the Buddhist faith from India, which transformed Chinese culture and thought.

As pointed out in Chapter 4, Buddhism began to take root in China and become a popular faith only after the break-up of the Han empire (206 BCE – 220 CE ). There was a period of nearly 400 years when there was constant war and turmoil and large parts of the country were overrun by the semi-nomadic tribes which ranged across China’s western and northern peripheries. This was a period of constant mingling of different ethnic groups, including the invading tribes as well as the largely autonomous peoples inhabiting the southern regions south of the Yangzi river, over which central rule had remained tenuous. As the pressures on the northern heartland intensified, the ruling elites moved to the south. Over these